

CAPTAIN AMERICA



Wolverine sneaks onto the SHIELD Helicarrier to inspect Steve Rogers' body.

After the announcement of the Superhuman Registration Act, Captain America (Steve Rogers) could not stomach enforcing what he considered to be an unjust law. He broke with his old friend Tony Stark (IRON MAN) and formed a resistance movement to help unwilling heroes to defy the law. This split fractured the superhero community and set the heroes against each other in what would become known as the Civil War (see pp. 84–5). At the end of the war, Iron Man defeated and captured Rogers, who was soon after assassinated as he was brought into a federal courthouse in New York City.

IN DEATH'S SHADOW

Without Rogers to lead it, the organized resistance against the Superhuman Registration Act fell apart. Many of the heroes who had held out stepped forward to register. The Falcon, for instance, signed up solely so he could appear at Rogers's funeral.

Having seen many people supposedly die in the past, including Rogers himself, some heroes refused at first to believe that he was dead. It was only after Iron Man and WOLVERINE—each representing a different side in the Civil War—were able to corroborate Rogers's death that the reality began to sink in.

THE HUNT FOR A NEW CAPTAIN

Although Stark had gone on record stating that no one would replace Captain America, it wasn't long until he went looking for a replacement. With Captain America's costume and indestructible shield in SHIELD custody, he could give the assignment to whoever he liked. When Stark discovered that Clint Barton (HAWKEYE) had somehow survived the SCARLET WITCH's disassembling of the Avengers, he brought Barton aboard the SHIELD Helicarrier to show him the original shield, revealing that he'd had two imperfect copies made. The first sat on display at the Smithsonian, while the second was to be buried with Rogers. The real one was

up for grabs.

Barton tried out the shield, becoming the first person to wield it properly after 77 other people had failed. Stark gave Barton the shield and the costume to try out as he went to arrest PATRIOT and the new Hawkeye for failure to comply with the Superhuman Registration Act. At the moment of truth, Barton—dressed in Rogers's uniform and holding his shield—let the two heroes go rather than arrest them. He then gave the shield back to Stark.

BUCKY CLAIMS THE SHIELD

Unwilling to let Rogers's shield languish in the custody of SHIELD—which he blamed in part for Rogers's death—Bucky BARNES stole it. Back

conditions. First, any secret mental conditioning from his days as the Winter Soldier had to be telepathically removed. Second, he would answer only to himself. Knowing that this would be exactly what Rogers would have wanted, Stark accepted the deal.

Feeling unfit to wear Rogers's own costume, Barnes had a new one designed for himself. Unlike Rogers, Barnes was happy to use weaponry of all sorts in his battles, not just the shield. He carried a pistol and a combat knife on his belt, which featured a number of pouches, and he brought in other ordnance as necessary.



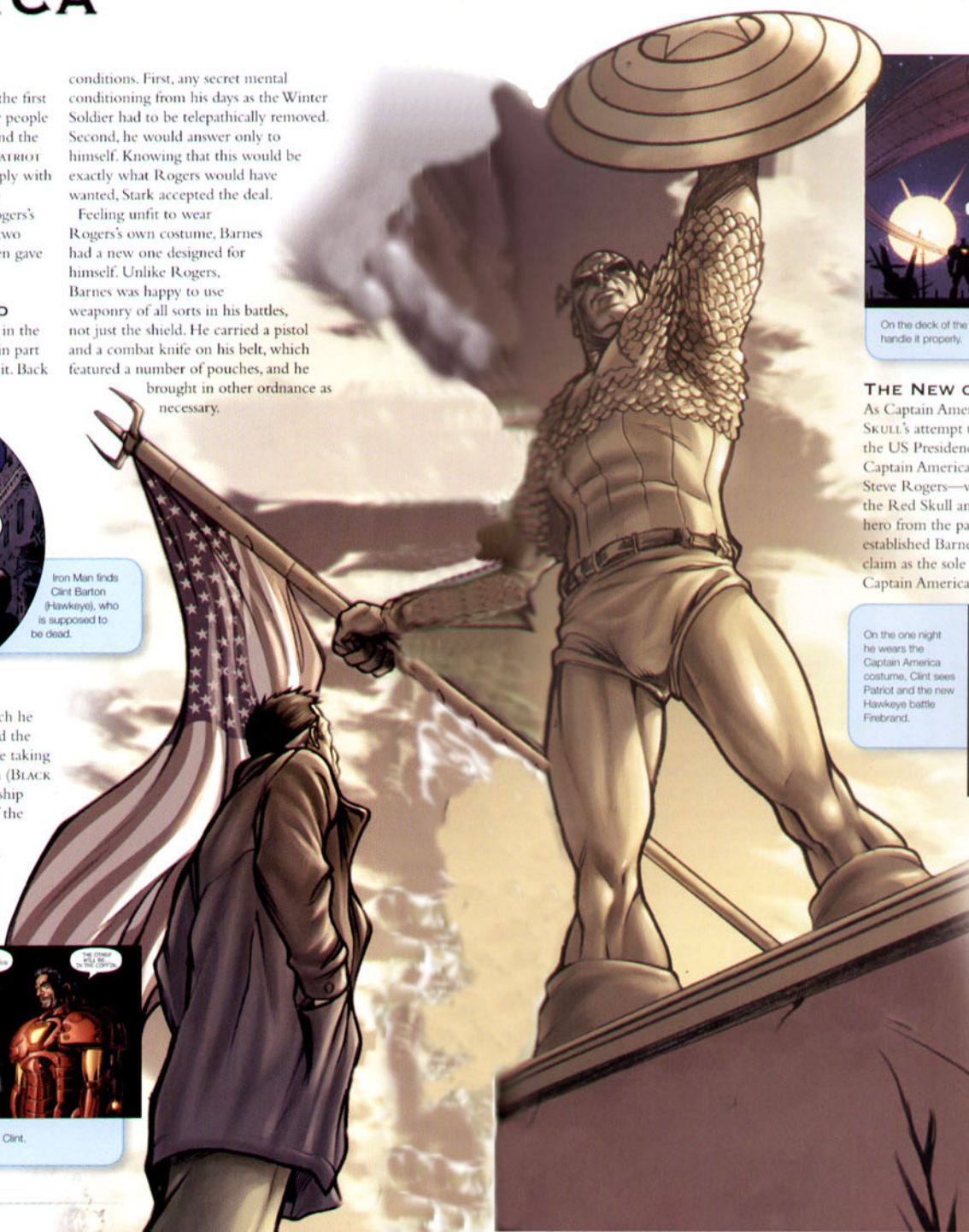
Iron Man finds Clint Barton (Hawkeye), who is supposed to be dead.

from his own purported death, after which he had become the WINTER SOLDIER, he used the shield in a few missions of his own. While taking the shield, he ran into Natasha Alianovna (BLACK WIDOW), with whom he'd had a relationship when they'd both been in the employ of the Soviet Union.

After SHIELD finally captured Barnes, Stark surprised him by offering him the identity of Captain America to go along with the shield. Barnes accepted on two



Iron Man presents Captain America's original shield to Clint.



On the deck of the Helicarrier, Clint gives the shield a try—and is the first to be able to handle it properly.

THE NEW CAPTAIN AMERICA

As Captain America, Barnes foiled the RED SKULL's attempt to assassinate both candidates for the US Presidency. He also faced off against the Captain America of the 1950s—also known as Steve Rogers—who had been brainwashed by the Red Skull and Dr. FAUSTUS. Defeating this hero from the past and restoring his mind established Barnes's claim as the sole Captain America.

On the one night he wears the Captain America costume, Clint sees Patriot and the new Hawkeyes battle Firebrand.



once led. He allowed them to use his secret home in an old warehouse as their base of operations. Barnes worked with them under the leadership of Barton, now calling himself Ronin. Barnes also renewed his relationship with the Black Widow and worked closely with her and the Falcon on many of his missions.

While still struggling to fill Roger's boots, Barnes dedicated himself to being worthy of the honor of wearing the mantle of the icon of his country. He knew he had a lot to make up for from his days as the Winter Soldier, but he was living proof of what people could do with second chances. **MF**

When Bucky agreed to become Captain America, he designed a new costume for the role.